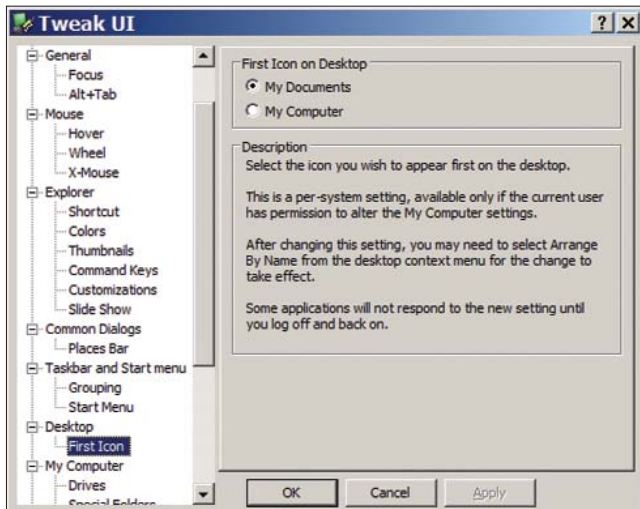




TweakUI has hundreds of hidden tweaks that you would never come across when working normally with Windows XP. You have to install it to believe the customisability that it offers

Unlike previous versions of TweakUI, TweakUI for Windows XP is a standalone executable. This means you should delete any old copies of TweakUI before installing this version. The PowerToy features a cascading tree view of options on the left, and selecting any option will display configuration options on the right.

You can do all kinds of things with this PowerToy. You can configure various UI effects, such as menu fading, error beeping, cursor shadow, and the like. You can configure the mouse, the taskbar, and the desktop. You can edit common dialogs, and determine the location of special shell folders, such as the CD burning cache. You can also do things like preventing drives from showing up in Explorer.

TweakUI for Windows XP is definitely something that should have been inbuilt in XP!

Webcam Timershot

 This is a good Web camera tool that offers a lot of functionality. It can capture images from the camera at specific intervals and automatically save it to a location, even an FTP or Web site. The sheer number of options is impressive: when you hit the expand button, the window opens up four-fold, with options for choosing the picture-taking interval,

whether to resize the images, the local or Internet destination for saving the files, and other options.

Windows XP General Tips

Change The Start Menu Speed

 You might want to change the delay you notice when you click the Start menu. The default speed can be adjusted with a quick Registry hack. Go to the Registry key `HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Control Panel\Desktop\MenuShowDelay`. The default value is 400. Set it to 0 to remove the delay completely, but if you do that, it will be nearly impossible to move the mouse fast enough not to activate 'All Programs' if you mouse over it while going to your selection. Pick a number that suits you, make the change, and test it until you find a good compromise between speed and usability.

Place The Windows Kernel Into RAM

 Anything that runs in RAM will, of course, be faster than something that has to access the hard drive and virtual memory. Rather than have the kernel that is the foundation of XP using the slower Paging Executive

functions, use this hack—but only if your system has 256 MB or more of RAM.

Change the value of `HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\SYSTEM\CurrentControlSet\Control\Session Manager\Memory Management\DisablePagingExecutive` to "1" to disable paging and have the kernel run in RAM. Set the value to "0" to undo the hack). Exit the Registry and reboot.

Alter Prefetch Parameters

 Prefetching (the reading of system boot files into a cache for faster loading) is a commonly overlooked component that can have a significant impact on system boot time. This tweak allows you to select which components will make use of the prefetch parameters. To see which files are gathered using each setting, clear the prefetch cache located at `C:\Windows\Prefetch`, and then enable one of the settings listed here. Clear the cache and repeat for each setting.

Set the Registry key `HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\SYSTEM\CurrentControlSet\Control\Session Manager\Memory Management\PrefetchParameters\EnablePrefetcher` to "0" to disable prefetching, "1" to prefetch application launch files, "2" to prefetch boot files, or "3" to prefetch as many files as possible.

Disable 8.3 Name Creation In NTFS

 Files that use the 8.3 naming convention can degrade NTFS drive performance. Unless you have a good reason for keeping the 8.3 naming convention intact (such as if you're using 16-bit programs), a performance gain can be achieved by disabling it.

Set the Registry DWORD key `HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\SYSTEM\CurrentControlSet\Control\FileSystem\NtfsDisable8dot3NameCreation` to "1". Exit the Registry and reboot.

Perform A Boot Defragment

 There's a simple way to speed up XP startup: make your system do a boot defragment, which will put all the boot files next to each other on your hard disk. When boot files are in close proximity to each other, your system will start faster.

On most systems, boot defragment should be enabled by default, but it might not be on yours, or it might have been changed inadvertently. To make sure boot defragment is enabled on your system, run the Registry Editor and go to `HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\SOFTWARE\Microsoft\Dfrg\BootOptimizeFunction`. Edit the "Enable" string value to "Y" if it is not already set to this. Exit the Registry and reboot.

Don't Empty The Prefetch Folder

 Many people recommending a way of speeding up boot times that might in fact slow down the amount of time it takes to boot up, and will probably slow down launching applications as well: the tip recommends going to your `C:\WINDOWS\Prefetch` directory and emptying it every week. Windows uses this directory to speed up launching applications. It analyses the files you use during startup and the applications you launch, and it creates an index to where those files and applications are located on your hard disk. By using this index, XP can launch files and applications faster. So, by emptying the directory, you are most likely slowing down application launch.

Hack Your BIOS For Faster Startups

 Most people don't realise that you can also speed up the time your computers get to Windows. **☑ Quick Power On Self Test (POST)** When you choose this option, your system runs an abbreviated POST rather than the normal, lengthy one.